truncated schedule, Indian clubs will manage around 13, thus losing direct slots and slipping into qualifiers.

Financially, the situation remains precarious. An official at one ISL club said primary distribution for each club from the central revenue pool was roughly Rs 13 crore in 2024–25. "With the extra Rs 5-6 crore from sponsorship, you could soften the blow," he says. "Without both, some clubs are staring at a Rs 18-19 crore annual deficit." Even so, clubs need the league, because without it, careers would stall overnight.

Below the Indian Super League, the I-League, Indian football's second division, is gasping for breath too. With no firm making a bid for commercial rights, sponsorship has dried up. Here also, the season that kicked off on February 21 will be a shortened one.

'A DIFFICULT TIME'

For India's footballing community, the pain is very real. A former India international, now an assistant coach at an ISL club, says he has not been paid for 10 months. "It has been a difficult time for my family," he says. At least seven clubs temporarily shut activities to cut costs. One suspended salaries till December, promising staggered clearance between January and May. Another negotiated one- or two-month pay cuts. Chennaiyin FC defender Pritam Kotal has been without club football since October. He trained at an academy he helped set up and turned out for his central government employers on uneven pitches. "It's not ideal, but you do what you can to stay in touch," he said.

In this fight for survival, national captain Chhetri played pickleball to stay in shape; coach and former player Ishfaq Ahmed worked with juniors while waiting for the I-League and, after completing his tenure with Gokulam Kerala in 2025, Ranjan Singh Salam played the state-level Kerala league. Similarly, out-of-contract I-League players turned out in the Bangalore Football League.

But even with all this turmoil, AIFF president Kalyan Chaubey likes to call 2025 a year of successes. "For the first time, all three women's teams—the senior national team, the U-20 national team, and the U-17 national team—qualified for the AFC Asian Cup on merit. This marked a milestone in Indian football," he says, adding that the U-17 boys' team qualified for the continental tournament after defeating top-ranked Iran. "The year also witnessed the establishment of the first FIFA–AIFF Girls' Academy and the launch of the second FIFA-AIFF Boys' Academy in Hyderabad," Chaubey says.



"By now, we should be on your screens playing competitive football in the ISL. Instead, we are driven by fear and desperation..."

GURPREET SINGH SANDHU
Member of the Indian football team, in a players' video appeal to FIFA



"We ignore the ISL's mediocrity as a sporting product. From a footballing perspective, it has failed to mature into a compelling, sustainable competition"

KUSHAL DAS
Former AIFF general secretary

Yet the men's national team has failed to qualify for the 24-team AFC Asian Cup after losing to Singapore in October 2025. Its freefall can be attributed to a fractured domestic calendar, an uncertain second division and players going without competitive football for months. The team's slide in the FIFA rankings is not sudden, for rankings depend on numbers of international matches, quality opponents and consistency in performance. India has struggled with all three. While its Asian peers like Japan, South Korea, Iran, Uzbekistan, Jordan and Vietnam operate on a different footballing ecosystem, India has been a laggard, struggling to organise its own season on time, to keep its second tier alive and to give its professionals the best of conditions.

Paradoxically, India remains one of the most lucrative television markets for global football events like the English Premier League and the FIFA World Cup. But fans who stay up for Liverpool or Manchester City matches do not show up on a Saturday evening for the ISL because the league itself has struggled to grow sporting credibility.

"We often ignore the ISL's mediocrity as a sporting product," says former AIFF general secretary Kushal Das. "From a footballing perspective, the league has failed to mature into a compelling, sustainable competition." He argues that despite optimistic projections, most clubs have shallow fan bases and minimal contribution to the national pool.

Decisions at the top have further dented confidence. In 2022, the withdrawal of India's bid to host the AFC Asian Cup 2027, despite advanced preparations, stunned the football community. "Our current focus is building the foundations of a proper footballing structure before thinking of hosting bigger events," the AIFF had stated.

For players and coaches, football is a job measured in match minutes, fitness cycles and contracts honoured. The ISL may have been saved for now, but until proper governance and commercial clarity return, Indian football will keep playing on injury time, hoping the whistle does not blow before stability arrives. ■